

[TITLE — choose from the options above or write your own]

[Full name]

[School], Rawalpindi, Pakistan

[Month] 2026

Abstract

1 Introduction

2 Preliminaries

Definition 2.1 (Positions and outcomes). A terminal position (no legal moves) is a P-position; a position is an N-position if and only if at least one legal move reaches a P-position; a position is a P-position if and only if every legal move reaches an N-position, the terminal case satisfying this clause vacuously.

Lemma 2.2 (Verification principle; see, e.g., [9]). *Let S be a set of positions of an impartial game under normal play. If (i) every terminal position lies in S , (ii) no move from a position in S leads to a position in S , and (iii) from every position not in S some move leads to a position in S , then S is exactly the set of P-positions.*

Definition 2.3 (The diagonal games $D(m, r)$). Let $m \geq 2$ and $0 \leq r \leq m - 1$. $D(m, r)$ is played on the non-negative integers. From a position $n \equiv r \pmod{m}$ (*squares mode*) a move subtracts any square k^2 with $k \geq 1$ and $k^2 \leq n$. From any other position (*fallback mode*) the only move subtracts m , available when $n \geq m$. Play is normal.

Definition 2.4 (Squares modulo $2m$). $\mathcal{Q}(2m)$ denotes the set of residues of squares modulo $2m$. The mirror tool, proved once in general: $(2m - k)^2 = 4m^2 - 4mk + k^2 \equiv k^2 \pmod{2m}$, since $4m^2 = 2m \cdot 2m$ and $4mk = 2k \cdot 2m$. So every table is $k = 1..m$ plus mirrors, plus the 0 from $k = 2m$. Two side facts fell out of the mirrors and are used below: for odd m , $m^2 - m = m(m - 1)$ has the even factor $m - 1$, so $m^2 \equiv m \pmod{2m}$; for even m , $m^2 = (m/2) \cdot 2m \equiv 0 \pmod{2m}$.

The mod-4 and mod-8 rows are the indictment written out: $\mathcal{Q}(4) = \{0, 1\}$ and $\mathcal{Q}(8) = \{0, 1, 4\}$ both sit entirely inside the triple $\{0, 1, m\}$, so their complements swallow every value any hard set will ever contain (Section 4) — the disease of $m = 2$ and $m = 4$ is visible in these two rows before any game logic starts. One eyebrow kept raised on purpose: the thinnest *odd* table is mod 18, thinned because 9 is itself a square and the rows $k = 3$ and $k = 9$ collide there — $m = 9$'s anomaly is foreshadowed in its own table.

mod	$\mathcal{Q}(2m)$	complement
4	$\{0, 1\}$	$\{2, 3\}$
6	$\{0, 1, 3, 4\}$	$\{2, 5\}$
8	$\{0, 1, 4\}$	$\{2, 3, 5, 6, 7\}$
10	$\{0, 1, 4, 5, 6, 9\}$	$\{2, 3, 7, 8\}$
12	$\{0, 1, 4, 9\}$	$\{2, 3, 5, 6, 7, 8, 10, 11\}$
14	$\{0, 1, 2, 4, 7, 8, 9, 11\}$	$\{3, 5, 6, 10, 12, 13\}$
18	$\{0, 1, 4, 7, 9, 10, 13, 16\}$	$\{2, 3, 5, 6, 8, 11, 12, 14, 15, 17\}$
22	$\{0, 1, 3, 4, 5, 9, 11, 12, 14, 15, 16, 20\}$	$\{2, 6, 7, 8, 10, 13, 17, 18, 19, 21\}$

Table 1: The engines at every modulus: $\mathcal{Q}(2m)$ with complements.

3 The Chain Lemma

Lemma 3.1 (Chain Lemma). *Fix integers $m \geq 2$ and $0 \leq r \leq m - 1$, and let c be any residue with $0 \leq c \leq m - 1$ and $c \neq r$. In $D(m, r)$, for every position $n \geq 0$ with $n \equiv c \pmod{m}$:*

$$n \text{ is a P-position} \iff n \equiv c \pmod{2m}.$$

Proof. Setup and notation. Chain c is the set $\{c + jm : j = 0, 1, 2, \dots\}$, i.e. all positions $\equiv c \pmod{m}$; call $c + jm$ rung j . Two arithmetic remarks used throughout. (i) Every rung satisfies $c + jm \equiv c \not\equiv r \pmod{m}$, so every position of the chain is in fallback mode: its only candidate move is subtract- m , legal exactly when the position is $\geq m$. (ii) Since $n \equiv c \pmod{m}$, the residue of $n \bmod 2m$ is either c or $c + m$; and $n = c + jm \equiv c \pmod{2m} \iff 2m$ divides $jm \iff j$ is even. So the Lemma is equivalent to: rung j is P iff j is even. (All outcome computations below use Definition 2.1.)

Closure. Let $n = c + jm$ be a rung. Its only candidate move is $n \rightarrow n - m$. If $j = 0$, the move is illegal, since $n = c \leq m - 1 < m$. If $j \geq 1$, the move is legal, since $n = c + jm \geq 0 + m = m$, and it lands on $c + (j - 1)m$: the same residue $c \bmod m$, hence rung $j - 1$ of the same chain. So every legal move from a chain- c position stays inside chain c , descending exactly one rung, and the set of positions reachable from the chain is contained in the chain.

Independence. Positions outside chain c — in particular class- r positions firing squares — may well have moves that land on rungs of the chain. This cannot disturb the rungs' statuses: by the definition just quoted, the status of a position is a function only of the statuses of its options, the positions reachable from it; the definition never mentions moves arriving at a position. By Closure, every option of every rung is again a rung, so the statuses of chain c are computed entirely within chain c and would be identical if the rest of $D(m, r)$ were deleted. Incoming traffic affects only the travellers, never the rungs.

The bottom. Rung 0 is the position c , the least element of the chain, with $0 \leq c \leq m - 1$. It is in fallback mode (because $c \not\equiv r$) and its single candidate move is illegal (because $c < m$). Both facts hold equally for $c = 0$ and for $c \geq 1$ — note that for $c = 0$ no appeal to squares is needed: $0 \neq r$ already puts the position 0 in fallback mode, where $m \leq 0$ fails. So rung 0 is terminal, hence a P-position: “every legal move reaches an N” holds vacuously. This matches the claim, since $j = 0$ is even.

Alternation. Claim: rung j is P for even j and N for odd j . Strong induction on j . Base, $j = 0$: done above. Step, $j \geq 1$: assume the claim for all smaller indices. By Closure, rung j has exactly one legal move — legal precisely because $j \geq 1$, the boundary check (rung 0 has

no move at all; rung 1's move is legal since $c + m \geq m$ — and it goes to rung $j - 1$. For a position with a single option x , the definition specializes: “some option is P” means x is P, so the position is N iff x is P; “every option is N” means x is N, so the position is P iff x is N. By the induction hypothesis, rung $j - 1$ is P iff $j - 1$ is even. Hence rung j is N iff $j - 1$ is even, i.e. iff j is odd; and rung j is P iff $j - 1$ is odd, i.e. iff j is even. Induction closed.

Assembly. Let $c \neq r$ be any class and $n \equiv c \pmod{m}$ any position; write $n = c + jm$ with $j \geq 0$ uniquely determined. Closure and Independence license computing n 's status inside the chain alone; the bottom is the base of the induction and Alternation is its step, giving: n is P $\iff j$ is even $\iff jm \equiv 0 \pmod{2m}$ $\iff n \equiv c \pmod{2m}$. Nothing about c was used beyond $0 \leq c \leq m - 1$ and $c \neq r$, so the result holds for all $m - 1$ such classes simultaneously. $\square$

4 Escape: the Clearing Lemma and its exceptions

Lemma 3.1 classifies no position of class r itself — it is silent about every $n \equiv r \pmod{m}$, and in particular does not assert those are N-positions; that claim is the subject of the present section, and only the two together give the full mod- $2m$ law.

Definition 4.1 (Window; free and hard residues; hard set). By Lemma 3.1, each class $c \neq r$ is a self-contained chain whose P-positions are exactly $n \equiv c \pmod{2m}$. The window $T(m, r)$ is the set of foreign bottoms mod $2m$. Class r splits mod $2m$ into the **free residue** (r when $r \geq 1$, else m) and the **hard residue** ($r + m$ when $r \geq 1$, else 0). The free escape is immediate: 1^2 lands the free residue on the bottom directly beneath it ($r - 1$, or $m - 1$ when $r = 0$), and is legal from the smallest free member. For the hard residue, a square value $s \pmod{2m}$ lands in the window iff

$$s \in H(m, r) = \{r + 1, \dots, m - 1\} \cup \{m + 1, \dots, m + r\} \text{ for } r \geq 1, \\ \text{or } \{m + 1, \dots, 2m - 1\} \text{ for } r = 0.$$

Lemma 4.2 (Constitutional uselessness). *For every m and r : $0, 1, m \notin H(m, r)$; a square $\equiv 0$ or $m \pmod{2m}$ is $\equiv 0 \pmod{m}$ and keeps a class- r position inside class r ; and subtracting a square $\equiv 1 \pmod{2m}$ from the hard residue lands one below it in the top half, an N-position.*

Proof. The exclusions $0, 1, m \notin H(m, r)$ are read directly off the displayed form of H . A square $\equiv 0$ or $m \pmod{2m}$ is $\equiv 0 \pmod{m}$, so subtracting it keeps a class- r position inside class r ; and subtracting a square $\equiv 1 \pmod{2m}$ from the hard residue lands one below it in the top half — the odd rung directly above a bottom — an N-position. $\square$

Lemma 4.3 (Clearing Lemma). *Suppose some square $s \neq m$ lies in the integer interval $(r, m + r]$ when $r \geq 1$, or in $(m, 2m)$ when $r = 0$. Then the entire hard class is N by the single move $-s$.*

Proof. Legality: $s \leq m + r$, the smallest hard member (for $r = 0$: $s < 2m$, and the smallest positive hard member is $2m$), so the move is affordable to every member from the first. Landing: $n - s \equiv m + r - s \pmod{2m}$ is a foreign bottom — in (r, m) when $r < s < m$, in $[0, r)$ when $m < s \leq m + r$; for $r = 0$, the landing $2m - s$ lies in $(0, m)$. Combined with the free escape, class r is all N — except possibly $n = 0$, handled in Lemma 4.7. $\square$

Lemma 4.4 (The interval contains a square). *For $m \geq 3$ and $1 \leq r \leq m - 1$, the interval $(r, m + r]$ contains a square. For $r = 0$, the interval $(m, 2m)$ contains a square for every $m \geq 3$ except $m = 4$.*

Proof. For $r \geq 1$: if $(r, m+r]$ contained no square, consecutive squares would straddle it, $c^2 \leq r$ and $(c+1)^2 > m+r$, so $2c+1 > m$, hence $c \geq m/2$ for any m , hence $c^2 \geq m^2/4 > m-1 \geq r$, since $m^2/4 - (m-1) = (m-2)^2/4 > 0$ for $m \geq 3$ — contradicting $c^2 \leq r$. The inequality degenerates at exactly one modulus, $m = 2$, where $(m-2)^2 = 0$ and the interval can indeed be empty ($(1, 3]$ in $D(2, 1)$ contains no square). Erratum, folded in: for $r = 0$ the interval reads $(m, 2m)$, which contains a square for every $m \geq 3$ **except** $m = 4$ — $(4, 8) = \{5, 6, 7\}$ is square-free, and it is the lone counterexample, since the same consecutive-squares squeeze forces emptiness only for $m \leq 5$, and $m = 3$ has its 4, $m = 5$ its 9. $\square$

Proposition 4.5 (The failure window). *The hypothesis of Lemma 4.3 fails for $r \geq 1$ only if $m = b^2$ with $(b-1)^2 \leq r \leq 2b$, which is possible only for $b \leq 3$: among $m \geq 3$, exactly $m = 4$ ($r \in \{1, 2, 3\}$) and $m = 9$ ($r \in \{4, 5, 6\}$).*

Proof. With a square always present, the Clearing Lemma’s hypothesis can fail for $r \geq 1$ only if the *unique* square in $(r, m+r]$ is m itself: $m = b^2$ with $(b-1)^2 \leq r$ (no smaller square intrudes) and $(b+1)^2 > m+r$, i.e. $r \leq 2b$. The window $(b-1)^2 \leq r \leq 2b$ is nonempty iff $(b-1)^2 \leq 2b$ iff $b \leq 3$. Among $m \geq 3$ that leaves exactly $m = 4$ ($b = 2$, $r \in \{1, 2, 3\}$) and $m = 9$ ($b = 3$, $r \in \{4, 5, 6\}$). With the $r = 0$ erratum, every class of $m = 4$ is condemned from the outside — no clearing square exists for any r — while $m = 9$ is healthy at every r except 4, 5, 6. Squarehood of m alone is harmless: at $m = 25$ ($b = 5$) the neighboring square 36 sits only $2b+1 = 11$ above m , deep inside a 25-wide window, so it invades $(r, m+r]$ for every r ; a square m isolates itself only when the modulus is small enough ($b \leq 3$) for square-gaps to outrun m . $\square$

Proposition 4.6 (The rebels). *For $(m, r) \in \{(9, 4), (9, 5), (9, 6)\}$ the position $n = m+r$ is a P-position, and it is the unique P-position of $D(m, r)$ outside the window.*

Proof. At $(9, r)$ with $r \in \{4, 5, 6\}$, the smallest hard member $n_0 = m+r \in \{13, 14, 15\}$ can afford only the squares $k^2 \leq r$ and 9. A square $k^2 \leq r$ lands on $m+(r-k^2)$, the odd rung directly above bottom $r-k^2$ — N. The square 9 lands on r itself, the smallest free member — N, since it escapes by 1^2 . Every move lands on N, so n_0 is P. In-game receipts: in $D(9, 4)$, $13 \rightarrow 12, 9, 4$, all N; in $D(9, 5)$, $14 \rightarrow 13, 10, 5$, all N; in $D(9, 6)$, $15 \rightarrow 14, 11, 6$, all N. Above the rebel the class closes uniformly: the members $27+r$ (31, 32, 33) are cleared by $25 \equiv 7 \pmod{18}$, which lies in all three hard sets, landing on bottoms 6, 7, 8; the members $45+r$ (49, 50, 51) by $49 \equiv 13$, landing on bottoms 0, 1, 2; and from $63+r \geq 64 = (m-1)^2$ onward, the witness $64 \equiv 10 = m+1$ lands on bottom $r-1$ forever. So each exceptional game carries exactly one extra P-position, and the exception set is precisely the set E of Theorem 5.1. $\square$

Lemma 4.7 (Boundary positions corrupt nothing). *In $D(m, r)$: (i) if $r = 0$ then $n = 0$ is a P-position, and its status alters no other position’s; (ii) for $(m, r) \in E$, the P-position $n = m+r$ alters no other position’s status.*

Proof. **Corruption audits.** The $n = 0$ clause: when $r = 0$, zero is claimed by squares mode and is the unique squares-mode position that can afford no square ($k \geq 1$ forces $k^2 \geq 1 > 0$), so it is terminal, hence P — while the unamended law would file residue 0 as N. It corrupts nobody: fallback chains never visit class 0; the positions that can drop to 0 are $n = k^2 \equiv 0 \pmod{m}$, class-0 members the theorem already declares N; and the classes above escape without it — spot receipts: $10 - 9 = 1$ (P) in $D(5, 0)$, $14 - 9 = 5$ (P) in $D(7, 0)$. For $r \geq 1$ the clause is absorbed, since 0 is itself a foreign bottom; it earns its keep exactly at $r = 0$. The rebels, one sentence in the same mirror: a rebel corrupts nobody either — fallback chains never enter class

r , and the only positions with a move onto $m + r$ are class- r members above it (a square step back into class r forces $k^2 \equiv 0 \pmod{9}$, i.e. $3 \mid k$), which the theorem already declares N, so the rebel's P-ness merely hands them one more witness for what they already were. $\square$

5 The Diagonal Theorem

Theorem 5.1 (Diagonal Law). *Let $m \geq 3$ with $m \neq 4$, and let $0 \leq r \leq m - 1$. Define $E = \{(9, 4), (9, 5), (9, 6)\}$. In $D(m, r)$, a position n is a P-position if and only if*

$$\begin{aligned} n \equiv b \pmod{2m} \text{ for some foreign bottom } b \in \{0, 1, \dots, m - 1\} \setminus \{r\}, \\ \text{or } n = 0, \quad \text{or } (m, r) \in E \text{ and } n = m + r. \end{aligned}$$

The law holds for both parities of m , with no thresholds and no unverified zones.

Proof. Fix a position n of $D(m, r)$ with $m \geq 3$, $m \neq 4$: either n lies in a class $c \not\equiv r \pmod{m}$, or n lies in class r , and in the latter case n is either a boundary position named in the statement — $n = 0$ when $r = 0$, or $n = m + r$ when $(m, r) \in E$ — or an ordinary class- r position, sitting by Definition 4.1 on either the free or the hard residue modulo $2m$; these buckets exhaust all n , and we take them in order. If n lies in a class $c \not\equiv r$, then by Lemma 3.1 (the Chain Lemma) its chain is self-contained and n is P exactly when $n \equiv c \pmod{2m}$ — precisely the foreign-bottom clause of the statement, so every such position carries its verdict. If n sits on the free residue, the move -1^2 is legal from the smallest free member onward and lands on the foreign bottom directly beneath ($r - 1$, or $m - 1$ when $r = 0$), a P-position *by the chain verdict of the previous sentence* (Lemma 3.1), so every free-residue position is N — and indeed the statement names no free residue among its P-positions. If n sits on the hard residue and $(m, r) \notin E$, then Lemma 4.4 together with Proposition 4.5 supplies a square $s \neq m$ in the clearing interval (the hypothesis $m \neq 4$ is load-bearing precisely here, since at $m = 4$ and only there they offer nothing for any r), and Lemma 4.3 converts that one square into the verdict: every hard-residue position is N by the single move $-s$, for both parities of m , the boundary $n = 0$ having already been set aside. If n is a class- r position with $(m, r) \in E$, Proposition 4.6 delivers the exceptional verdict: $n = m + r$ is P and is the unique off-window P-position, every other hard member being N, which combined with the free verdict above is exactly the exception clause of the statement. Finally, Lemma 4.7 certifies the boundary clauses and their harmlessness: $n = 0$ at $r = 0$ is terminal hence P, and neither its P-ness nor a rebel's disturbs any verdict already issued — every position with a move onto them is a class- r position ruled N above, and no fallback chain ever enters class r — so the classifications of the four preceding sentences stand undisturbed, and the P-positions of $D(m, r)$ are exactly those of the statement: the foreign bottoms modulo $2m$, together with $n = 0$, together with $n = m + r$ when $(m, r) \in E$. $\square$

Remark 5.2 (The historical witness). *The odd- m witness identity, the original route.* For odd m , $(m - 1)^2 = m^2 - 2m + 1 \equiv m^2 + 1 \equiv \mathbf{m} + \mathbf{1} \pmod{2m}$, using $m^2 \equiv m$ from Definition 2.4; and $m + 1$ belongs to every hard set, landing the hard residue exactly on bottom $r - 1$ ($m - 1$ when $r = 0$). So the pair $(1^2, (m - 1)^2)$ is a universal witness pair for all odd m at once — at the price of the threshold $n \geq (m - 1)^2$. The Clearing Lemma supersedes it: a square below $m + r$ does the same job with legality free, for both parities, with no threshold. The identity remains the cleanest line in this development and the historical door to everything above.

6 The diseased moduli

Lemma 6.1 (Confinement Lemma). *For $m \in \{2, 4\}$ and every r : $\mathcal{Q}(2m) \subseteq \{0, 1, m\}$, while $H(m, r)$ excludes 0, 1, and m . Hence no square move from a hard-residue position reaches the window: every move stays inside class r or lands on an N-position of a foreign chain.*

Proof. For $m \in \{2, 4\}$ and every r : $\mathcal{Q}(2m) \subseteq \{0, 1, m\}$ — read directly off the mod-4 and mod-8 rows of Table 1 — while every hard set $H(m, r)$ excludes 0, 1, and m (Definition 4.1). Hence from any hard-residue position, every legal square move either stays inside class r (a square $\equiv 0$ or $m \pmod{2m}$ is $\equiv 0 \pmod{m}$) or lands one below on the odd rung above a bottom (a square $\equiv 1$), an N-position — never on a P-position of a foreign chain. The argument is an only-options enumeration over $\mathcal{Q}(2m)$, the mirror image of the Independence step in the proof of Lemma 3.1 — there, fallback moves cannot leave a chain; here, square moves cannot leave the class except onto N. *Consequence:* the hard class’s P/N structure is decided by a self-contained internal recursion, and its very first member already defies the chain law: 3 is P in $D(2, 1)$ and 5 is P in $D(4, 1)$, where escape, if it existed, would force N. Calibration: for $m = 2$ and $m = 4$ we prove confinement — no square door into the window, so the class turns inward. We do **not** prove that these confined classes obey no eventual law of their own: “no period and no modulus up to 200 fits” is a reading from the search instrument, not a theorem, and their aperiodicity remains open. $\square$

Remark 6.2 (Double condemnation). The two diseased moduli are exactly the two the parity-free engine cannot serve. At $m = 2$ the engine is silent: the always-a-square inequality degenerates ($(m - 2)^2 = 0$) and the clearing interval $(1, 3]$ is genuinely square-free. At $m = 4$ the engine convicts every class from the outside: the failure window covers $r \in \{1, 2, 3\}$, and the $r = 0$ interval $(4, 8)$ is square-free. Outside view and inside view agree because both are reading the same two table rows: $\mathcal{Q}(2m) \subseteq \{0, 1, m\}$.

7 Further solved games

Example 7.1 ($D(5, 2)$, solved). A position n of $D(5, 2)$ is a P-position if and only if $n \equiv 0, 1, 3$, or $4 \pmod{10}$.

Step 1. Statement. There is an explicit threshold N_0 , computed in Step 6 below, such that every position $n \equiv 2 \pmod{5}$ with $n \geq N_0$ has at least one legal square move — some k with $k^2 \leq n$ — whose landing $n - k^2$ is a P-position of a fallback chain. Consequently every such n is an N-position.

Step 2. The target window. By the Chain Lemma, the fallback classes $0, 1, 3, 4 \pmod{5}$ have their P-positions exactly at $n \equiv 0, 1, 3, 4 \pmod{10}$; call that set $T = \{0, 1, 3, 4\} \pmod{10}$. A landing in T is genuinely P: a number $\equiv 0, 1, 3$, or $4 \pmod{10}$ is $\equiv 0, 1, 3$, or $4 \pmod{5}$, so it lives in a fallback chain where the lemma has jurisdiction, and its residue mod 10 matching the chain bottom’s means it sits an even number of rungs up — precisely the lemma’s P-rungs.

Step 3. The split. Write $n = 5q + 2$: if $q = 2t$ then $n = 10t + 2$, and if $q = 2t + 1$ then $n = 10t + 7$, so a class-2 position is $\equiv 2$ or $7 \pmod{10}$ — that is, r or $r + m$ — and the proof forks on the parity of q exactly the way the chain proof forked on the parity of j .

Step 4. Coverage line one. For $n \equiv 2 \pmod{10}$: the differences $2 - T$ are $\{2 - 0, 2 - 1, 2 - 3, 2 - 4\} \equiv \{2, 1, 9, 8\} \pmod{10}$, and intersecting with $\mathcal{Q} = \{0, 1, 4, 5, 6, 9\}$ leaves $\{1, 9\}$; take the smallest, $s = 1$, so subtracting 1^2 gives $n - 1 \equiv 1 \pmod{10} \in T$.

Step 5. Coverage line two. For $n \equiv 7 \pmod{10}$: the differences $7 - T$ are $\{7, 6, 4, 3\} \pmod{10}$, intersecting with $\mathcal{Q}$ leaves $\{4, 6\}$; take $s = 4$, so subtracting 2^2 gives $n - 4 \equiv 3 \pmod{10} \in T$. Both keystones came with a spare — $9 = 3^2$ also rescues residue 2, and $16 = 4^2$ also rescues residue 7. The corridor is wider than it needs to be.

Step 6. Legality and the threshold. The rescue squares are the concrete numbers 1 and 4. For the residue-2 class, whose members are $2, 12, 22, \dots$, legality demands $1 \leq n$, which already holds at the smallest member. For the residue-7 class, members $7, 17, 27, \dots$, legality demands $4 \leq n$, which holds at 7. So both rescues are legal for every member of their class, and the threshold collapses: $N_0 = 2$, the smallest class-2 position in existence. Below N_0 there are no class-2 positions at all, so the hand-check zone is empty — verdict: vacuous. Checking the small rows directly anyway: $2 - 1 = 1$ (P) ✓, $7 - 4 = 3$ (P) ✓, $12 - 1 = 11$ (P) ✓, $17 - 4 = 13$ (P) ✓, $22 - 1 = 21$ (P) ✓, $27 - 4 = 23$ (P) ✓. Every row is rescued-anyway, rebels: none. Worth recording why it collapsed: the rescue squares 1 and 4 happen to be smaller than the smallest members of their classes. Nothing guarantees that luck at other moduli, which is exactly why the theorem was written with N_0 as a named unknown.

Step 7. Assembly. The Chain Lemma classifies the four fallback classes everywhere: P exactly at $n \equiv 0, 1, 3, 4 \pmod{10}$, N at $5, 6, 8, 9$. The Escape Theorem classifies class 2 everywhere, since $N_0 = 2$ means “past the threshold” is all of it: residues 2 and 7 (mod 10) are all N. Union the two and every residue mod 10 is accounted for, with no unexplained positions beneath any threshold.

One coincidence too pretty not to flag: the P-set of the whole game *is* the target window T — the landing pads and the answer turned out to be the same four residues (resolved in Remark 7.3).

Step 8. Scope and the forward hook. The proof secretly depended on squares mod 10 being *rich*: $\mathcal{Q}$ fills six of the ten residues, enough that both difference lists $\{2, 1, 9, 8\}$ and $\{7, 6, 4, 3\}$ caught at least one member — had $\mathcal{Q}$ missed either list entirely, one residue of class 2 would have had no escape and the whole corridor would have collapsed. Generalizing to $D(m, r)$ therefore means asking whether that richness survives at other moduli — whether squares mod $2m$ keep intersecting the difference sets $\rho - T$ for both $\rho \in \{r, r + m\}$ — and since quadratic residues thin out and organize themselves as the modulus grows, that question, not the game logic, is precisely the content of Section 4.

Remark 7.2 (Verification against the workbook). Prediction first, then the rows: residue-2 positions (2, 12, 22) should be rescued by any legal square $\equiv 1$ or 9 (mod 10), residue-7 positions (7, 17) by any square $\equiv 4$ or 6 (mod 10), and every other square should be wasted.

- $n = 2$: only move $2 - 1 = 1$ (P). Predicted rescue 1^2 present ✓, nothing else in the row to waste.
- $n = 7$: $7 - 1 = 6$ (N), $7 - 4 = 3$ (P). Rescue 2^2 present ✓; the 1^2 is wasted exactly as the congruence says ($1 \notin \{4, 6\} \pmod{10}$, landing $\equiv 6$).
- $n = 12$: $12 - 1 = 11$ (P), $12 - 4 = 8$ (N), $12 - 9 = 3$ (P). Primary rescue 1^2 ✓, and the spare $9 = 3^2$ makes its first appearance in the first row big enough to afford it.
- $n = 17$: $17 - 1 = 16$ (N), $17 - 4 = 13$ (P), $17 - 9 = 8$ (N), $17 - 16 = 1$ (P). Primary 2^2 ✓ and spare 4^2 ✓.
- $n = 22$: $22 - 1 = 21$ (P), $22 - 4 = 18$ (N), $22 - 9 = 13$ (P), $22 - 16 = 6$ (N). Primary 1^2 ✓, spare 3^2 ✓.

The check came back stronger than required: not only does the predicted rescue sit in every row, every wasted square is wasted for the predicted reason — its residue misses the survivor set, and every wasted landing is $\equiv 6$ or 8 (mod 10), both N-residues. The congruence machinery

reproduces the workbook letter-for-letter, and the 200,000 mechanical sweep stands as the bulk consistency evidence behind it.

Remark 7.3 (The $D(5, 2)$ coincidence, resolved). For any escaped game the P-set equals its window by construction: $\text{P-set} = (\text{chain P's}) \cup (\text{class-}r \text{ P's}) = T \cup \emptyset = T$. The equality fails exactly where escape does — the three exceptional games have $\text{P-set} = T \cup \{m + r\}$, and the diseased games' P-sets properly contain their windows.

Theorem 7.4 (Foursquare). *Consider the game on $n \geq 0$: if $n \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, subtract any positive square $\leq n$; otherwise subtract $s \in \{3, 8, 9\}$, $s \leq n$; normal play. Then n is a P-position if and only if $n \equiv 0, 2, 4, \text{ or } 6 \pmod{16}$, for all $n \geq 0$ with no preperiod.*

Proof of Theorem 7.4. Let $S = \{n \geq 0 : n \equiv 0, 2, 4, 6 \pmod{16}\}$; since S and its complement are unions of residue classes modulo 16, every position lies in exactly one of the two. We verify the three conditions of Lemma 2.2 for S . (i) *Terminals*. The positions 0 and 2 are standard-mode (both $\not\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$) and every allowed move 3, 8, 9 exceeds them, so both are terminal. Conversely, every standard-mode $n \geq 3$ has the legal move 3, and every square-mode n has the legal move 1^2 , since square mode requires $n \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$ and hence $n \geq 1$. The terminal set is therefore exactly $\{0, 2\}$, and both members lie in S . (ii) *Closure*. Every element of S is even, hence $\not\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, hence standard-mode, so its moves are among 3, 8, 9. The moves 3 and 9 are odd, and even minus odd is odd, so their landings occupy odd residues modulo 16 — all outside the all-even S . The move 8 carries the residues $\{0, 2, 4, 6\}$ onto $\{8, 10, 12, 14\}$, also outside S . (Legality plays no role here: a move that does not exist cannot violate closure.) Hence no move from S lands in S . (iii) *Escape*. The complement of S consists of the even residues $\{8, 10, 12, 14\}$ together with the odd residues, and the odd residues split by mode: $\{3, 7, 11, 15\} (\equiv 3 \pmod{4})$ are standard, $\{1, 5, 9, 13\} (\equiv 1 \pmod{4})$ are square. The even non-candidates escape by subtracting 8, landing on $\{0, 2, 4, 6\} \subseteq S$, legal because the smallest member of each class is at least 8. The standard-mode odds escape by $3 \rightarrow 0$ (residue 3), $3 \rightarrow 4$ (residue 7), $9 \rightarrow 2$ (residue 11), and $9 \rightarrow 6$ (residue 15), legal at the smallest members 3, 7, 11, 15 respectively and a fortiori above. The square-mode odds escape by the squares 1^2 and 3^2 : subtracting 1 carries the residues $\{1, 5\}$ to $\{0, 4\}$, and subtracting 9 carries $\{9, 13\}$ to $\{0, 4\}$, legal since $1 \leq n$ whenever square mode applies and $9 \leq n$ on classes whose smallest members are 9 and 13. Every position outside S therefore has a move into S — and the verification consumes only the two instances $1^2 \equiv 1$ and $3^2 \equiv 9 \pmod{16}$; no general fact about squares is invoked. By Lemma 2.2, S is exactly the set of P-positions of Foursquare: the law $n \equiv 0, 2, 4, 6 \pmod{16}$ holds for every $n \geq 0$, with no preperiod. $\square$

Remark 7.5. Every odd square is congruent to 1 or 9 modulo 16: writing $(2m + 1)^2 = 4m(m + 1) + 1$, the product $m(m + 1)$ is even, so $4m(m + 1) \equiv 0 \text{ or } 8 \pmod{16}$. The proof above needs only the two instances $1^2 \equiv 1$ and $3^2 \equiv 9$; the general statement is recorded because the mechanism remark below leans on it.

Proposition 7.6 (Kadam's Extension). *Let F' be Foursquare with its standard-mode move set enlarged from $\{3, 8, 9\}$ to every $s \equiv 3, 8, \text{ or } 9 \pmod{16}$ with $s \leq n$, square mode unchanged. Then the P-positions of F' are exactly $n \equiv 0, 2, 4, 6 \pmod{16}$ — identical to Foursquare's. (Conjectured by Balaji Kadam, personal communication, July 2026.)*

Proof. Adding moves can only destroy terminality, never create it, so the terminals of F' lie among Foursquare's terminals $\{0, 2\}$, and both survive because the smallest member of the

extended set is still $3 > 2$ — the terminal set is $\{0, 2\}$, inside the candidate $\{0, 2, 4, 6\} \pmod{16}$. From a candidate position — even, hence standard mode — every legal move of F' subtracts some $s \equiv 3, 8$, or $9 \pmod{16}$, and the closure argument of Theorem 7.4 consumed exactly two facts about s , its parity and its residue modulo 16, never its actual size, so it transfers verbatim to every member of the extended family: the $s \equiv 3$ and $s \equiv 9$ moves are odd and land on odd residues, none of which lie in the all-even candidate, while the $s \equiv 8$ moves land on $\{8, 10, 12, 14\} \pmod{16}$, also outside — no move from the candidate returns to it. In the other direction, the extended move set contains the original one and square mode is untouched, so every escape witness of the original proof — the standard moves and the squares 1 and 9 — remains a legal move of F' with the same landing, and a move set that only grows cannot lose an escape: every position outside the candidate still has its move into it. The candidate therefore meets all three conditions of Lemma 2.2 in F' — terminals inside, closed against return, reachable from everywhere outside — so it is the P-set of F' , and it coincides with Foursquare's. $\square$

Remark 7.7 (The mechanism: why 16, and why $\{3, 8, 9\}$). Foursquare's board splits three ways, because square mode lives only at $n \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$: the evens, the standard-mode odds $\equiv 3, 7, 11, 15 \pmod{16}$, and the square-mode odds $\equiv 1, 5, 9, 13$. Within the evens, sort the standard moves by parity and the game simplifies at a stroke: 3 and 9 land among the odds, never on the all-even P-set, so the single even move 8 governs the even world alone. That world under one jump of 8 is precisely the shape of the Chain Lemma (Lemma 3.1) — four chains by residue modulo 8, with bottoms 0, 2, 4, 6 too poor to afford the jump, and a jump of size m minting a law of modulus $2m$ — so 8 mints 16, with P at the even rungs: $n \equiv 0, 2, 4, 6 \pmod{16}$, Theorem 7.4, its four residues revealed as chain bottoms; and running the law modulo 8 instead kills closure on the spot, $8 \rightarrow 0$ being a move from the candidate into itself. The honest experiment has two halves: restricted to the even world, $\{8\}$ alone reproduces the law perfectly to 2,000 — the governor proved on its own domain — while in the full game $\{8\}$ alone breaks at once, first at $n = 3$, exactly where the fired rescuers' constituents live. For 3 and 9 are not decoys: on the standard-mode odds, where squares are illegal, they are the sole rescuers — residue 3's only witness is 3 (to bottom 0), residue 7's is 3 (to 4), residue 11's is 9 (to 2), residue 15's is 9 (to 6) — while the squares police only their legal home, the value 1 carrying residues $\{1, 5\}$ to bottoms 0 and 4 and the value 9 carrying $\{9, 13\}$ to the same two bottoms. Here is the number-theoretic heart at its true address: odd squares modulo 16 take exactly two values, 1 and 9 (Remark 7.5), and the second is load-bearing precisely at residues 9 and 13 — the square-mode residues, no others — while modulo 8 every odd square is 1 and those residues would be stranded: the same poverty of squares modulo powers of two that confines $D(2, \cdot)$ and $D(4, \cdot)$, one refinement up and just barely wealth enough. So “why $\{3, 8, 9\}$ ” has its complete answer — three moves, three jobs, zero waste: one governor $\equiv 8 \pmod{16}$ whose doubling is the modulus, plus a pair of odd rescuers whose residues cover all four standard-odd classes; and the number 9's double life upgrades rather than dissolves — rescuer in both modes, carrying $\{11, 15\}$ as a move and $\{9, 13\}$ as a square, the entire upper odd world leaning on the value 9. The mechanism classifies tampering as well: an enlargement of the standard set leaves the P-set fixed exactly when every added move is either odd, landing, from any candidate position, on the all-N odd world, or $\equiv 8 \pmod{16}$, a clone of the governor — verified: 1, 5, and 24 preserve the law, 2, 4, and 16 break it at $n = 2, 4, 16$, and the maximal enlargement, every odd number plus the whole clone class, holds to 2,000. The extension of Proposition 7.6 adds precisely the residue classes of 3, 9, and 8 themselves, squarely inside the harmless family, so the conjecture is not merely true but forced — and busy rather than idle: below 3,000 the new moves serve as genuine witnesses at 1,490

positions, 746 of them odd, the smallest being $19 \rightarrow 0$, a new odd move rescuing its own residue. None of this replaces the verification proof, which remains the proof of record; it explains why the object that proof verified could not have looked any other way.

Proposition 7.8 (Odd-fallback collapse at $m = 2$). (Lemma A.) *For every odd integer $a \geq 1$, the set of P-positions (states n with $G(n) = 0$) consists precisely of all even integers. Consequently, the emergent period is 2 with a residue-set size of 1.*

(Lemma B.) *For all odd fallbacks $a, a' \geq 1$ and all states $n \geq 0$, the Grundy values satisfy $G_a(n) = G_{a'}(n)$.*

Proof. Setup. We fix $r = 1$: squares fire on odd n , and the fallback rule applies on even n , making the allowed move from n to $n - a$. Let $G(n)$ denote the Grundy value of state n , with $G(0) = 0$.

Lemma A (P-positions = Even Numbers). We proceed by induction on n .

Base case ($n = 0$). Terminal position, $G(0) = 0$, so 0 is a P-position.

Inductive step. Assume for all $k < n$ that $G(k) = 0 \iff k$ is even (equivalently, $G(k) > 0 \iff k$ is odd).

Case 1: n is even. The only available move is subtraction of the odd fallback a : $n \rightarrow n - a$. Since n is even and a is odd, the destination $n - a$ is strictly odd. By the induction hypothesis, $G(n - a) \neq 0$ (if $n - a \geq 0$), or the move set is empty (if $a > n$).

- If $a > n$: the move set is $\emptyset$, so $\text{mex}(\emptyset) = 0$ and $G(n) = 0$.
- If $a \leq n$: the set of reachable values is $\{G(n - a)\}$ with $G(n - a) \neq 0$, so $\text{mex}(\{G(n - a)\}) = 0$ and $G(n) = 0$.

In both cases $G(n) = 0$. Thus all even positions are P-positions.

Case 2: n is odd. The move set consists of square subtractions $n \rightarrow n - k^2$ for all integers $k \geq 1$ with $k^2 \leq n$. Choosing $k = 1$ gives a legal move to $n - 1$. Since n is odd, $n - 1$ is even, so $G(n - 1) = 0$ by the strong induction hypothesis. Thus $0 \in \{G(n - k^2) : k^2 \leq n\}$, forcing the mex to be positive, so $G(n) \neq 0$.

Therefore $G(n) = 0 \iff n \equiv 0 \pmod{2}$.

Lemma B (Full Sequence Equivalence). **Even positions.** What is $\text{mex}(\{v\})$ when $v \neq 0$, and what does that force $G(n)$ to be for even n ?

For even n , the reachable set is either empty (if $n < a$) or $\{G(n - a)\}$. By Lemma A, since $n - a$ is odd, $G(n - a) = v > 0$. Now $\text{mex}(\emptyset) = 0$, and $\text{mex}(\{v\}) = 0$ whenever $v > 0$. Therefore $G(n) = 0$ for every even n , regardless of the specific value of v , and regardless of whether the move exists at all. The parameter a evaporates at every even step.

Odd positions. At odd n , split the available squares k^2 by parity: which earlier positions' Grundy values enter the mex?

For odd n : if k is even, k^2 is even, so $n - k^2$ is odd; if k is odd, k^2 is odd, so $n - k^2$ is even. By Lemma A, for every odd k the landing $n - k^2$ is even with $G(n - k^2) = 0$. Thus the reachable Grundy values from odd n are $\{0\} \cup \{G(n - k^2) : k \text{ even}, k^2 \leq n\}$. The value 0 is guaranteed by the odd square moves ($k = 1, 3, 5, \dots$), and the non-zero entries depend exclusively on $G(n - k^2)$ for even k — landings on smaller odd numbers. So G at odd n is computed purely from earlier odd states, completely bypassing all even positions, and thus bypassing a entirely.

By induction on n : $G(0) = 0$; every even state yields $G = 0$ independent of a ; and every odd state's value is computed from prior odd states via even-square subtractions, in which a nowhere appears. The parameter a never impacts the Grundy sequence, so all odd fallbacks collapse to the exact same game. $\square$

8 Discovery methodology and retrodictions

The instrument behind the census is GameHunter, a closed loop of four parts: a proposer that mutates game rules, a Grundy engine that computes exact values, a battery of deterministic detectors that flag periodicity and modular structure, and an OEIS filter that discards anything already catalogued. It stands in a short lineage of proposing machines — Graffiti [10], the Ramanujan Machine [11], FunSearch [12] — and inherits their division of labor rather than their architectures. The trust ritual is fixed: before and after every session the engine re-derives five classical laws, the subtraction game $\{1, 2, 3\}$ and subtract-a-square among them, so that drift anywhere in the stack would announce itself in the classics before it could touch a hunt.

Seeded evolutionary hunts came first and surfaced the earliest solved games, Foursquare among them; systematic sweeps then enumerated the diagonal family, 1,120 games in the first sweep and 1,848 by the last, and the detectors read exact laws in 842 of them. Every law then survived six adversarial verification passes, at depth 20,000 and again at 10^6 , with zero failures; and when the 731 games that had resisted the detectors were rescanned at deeper range, only 6 converted. Both readings are therefore stable — and neither is a theorem: detector output is a finite-range reading, never a proof, which is why Sections 3 through 6 of this paper exist.

The division of labor is strict: GameHunter proposes and verifies mechanically, and proves nothing; every proof in this paper is human-written, and the repository’s contribution policy states the rule in writing. Hunts and sweeps are seeded, and every number in the previous paragraph regenerates from the seeded scripts at <https://github.com/hamzagul07/gamehunter>. The rule earns its keep for a reason with a date on it: during drafting, the author spent three documents faithfully verifying a subtly different game — correct simulations of the wrong object — and the error was caught at the door only because the workflow requires sentences to follow printouts, never precede them. The ritual is not ceremony; it is why that incident is a footnote and not a retraction.

Twice in this project the theory arrived after the numbers: mechanisms built weeks later re-derived, digit for digit, entries the instrument had logged as unexplained — coordinates recorded before any theory existed to predict them. The two retrodictions follow, and they speak for themselves.

Retrodiction I: the fingerprints

During the Chain Lemma verification sweeps — recorded weeks before any escape machinery existed — the ledger logged unexplained P-positions 3, 11, 23 in $D(2, 1)$ and 5, 13, 37 in $D(4, 1)$, anomalies with no mechanism attached. The Confinement Lemma now computes those games’ hard residues as 3 (mod 4) and 5 (mod 8), and all six fingerprints satisfy their congruence without exception. The theory did not accommodate old data; it specified coordinates for where lawlessness is possible, and data recorded before the theory existed turns out to have been sitting on those coordinates the entire time.

Retrodiction II: the $D(9, 4)$ receipt

Primary source, quoted verbatim from DIAGONAL_WORKBOOK.md and the raw JSON behind it:

```
| D(9,4) | mod 18 | P ≡ 0,1,2,3,5,6,7,8 | preperiod 14 | period 18 | swept 200,000 |  
{"game": [9,4], "preperiod": 14, "period": 18, "p_res": [0,1,2,3,5,6,7,8], "pre_P": [0,1,2,3,5,6,7,8,13]}
```

This line was recorded before the rebel mechanism existed, and the mechanism now derives every number on it with zero freedom. The rebel 13 is the lone off-residue P, named in the `pre_P` field. Any eventually-periodic fit beginning at or before 13 would propagate 13’s P-ness by the period, which the sweep refutes (31 is N); so every correct fit begins at 14, and the minimal preperiod is exactly rebel + 1 = 14. The period is $2m = 18$, and the P-residues are the foreign bottoms $\{0, \dots, 8\} \setminus \{4\} = \{0, 1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 7, 8\}$. Provenance note, owed and recorded: an earlier draft claimed from memory that every diagonal cell’s preperiod was ≤ 1 and built a certificate on that claim; the file said otherwise all along, the claim and the certificate are struck, and this line enters the paper as the primary-source receipt that replaced them.

9 Open question

What is proved about the two diseased moduli is confinement: for m in $\{2, 4\}$, no square move from the hard class reaches the window — every move either stays inside class r or lands on the N-rung of a foreign chain, and a foreign N-landing can never supply a P-witness — so the class’s P/N structure is a self-contained internal recursion, and escape is impossible as a theorem, not a reading. What is only observed is lawlessness: the instrument finds no period and no modulus up to 200 fitting the confined classes anywhere in a sweep to 200,000, and a finite-range reading, as Section 8 insists, is not a theorem. The problem, posed clean: decide whether the confined classes settle into an eventual law, or whether the census’s two stubborn columns are genuinely aperiodic. It sits beside Problem A1 of the Games of No Chance list [8] — the relationship between rule structure and period structure — and offers that problem its starkest small instance.

Open Problem. Is the set of P-positions of $D(2, 1)$ lying in the class $n \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ eventually periodic, and likewise for $D(4, 1)$ in the class $n \equiv 5 \pmod{8}$? We leave the reader $D(2, 1)$ as a parting gift: subtract any square from an odd number, subtract 2 from an even one — a pencil reaches 3, 11, and 23 inside an afternoon, and every theorem in this paper falls silent on what comes next.

Acknowledgments and AI disclosure

References

- [1] E. Duchêne and M. Rigo, Invariant games, *Theoret. Comput. Sci.* 411 (2010) 3169–3180.
- [2] S. W. Golomb, A mathematical investigation of games of “take-away”, *J. Combin. Theory* 1 (1966), no. 4, 443–458.
- [3] U. Larsson and I. Saha, A brief conversation about subtraction games, arXiv:2405.20054 (2024).
- [4] A. A. Siegel, Finite excluded subtraction sets and infinite modular Nim, M.Sc. thesis, Dalhousie University, 2005.
- [5] D. Sleator and M. Slusky, Subtraction games with FES sets of size 3, arXiv:1201.3299 (2012).
- [6] A. Holshouser and H. Reiter, One pile Nim with arbitrary move function, *Electron. J. Combin.* 10 (2003), #N7.

- [7] N. Fox, On aperiodic subtraction games with bounded Nim sequence, arXiv:1407.2823 (2014).
- [8] R. J. Nowakowski, Unsolved problems in combinatorial games, in *Games of No Chance 6* (U. Larsson, ed.), Math. Sci. Res. Inst. Publ. 71, Cambridge University Press, 2025, p. 43.
- [9] M. H. Albert, R. J. Nowakowski, and D. Wolfe, *Lessons in Play: An Introduction to Combinatorial Game Theory*, 2nd ed., A K Peters/CRC Press, 2019.
- [10] S. Fajtlowicz, On conjectures of Graffiti, *Discrete Math.* 72 (1988) 113–118.
- [11] G. Raayoni et al., Generating conjectures on fundamental constants with the Ramanujan Machine, *Nature* 590 (2021) 67–73.
- [12] B. Romera-Paredes et al., Mathematical discoveries from program search with large language models, *Nature* 625 (2024) 468–475.